

We've been discussing the free will defense as a response to the argument from evil. This response assumes something about us: that we have free will.

But what does this mean?

To say that we have free will is to say that some of our actions are up to us; it is to say that, at least sometimes, we have the ability to choose what we do.

Is it true that some of our actions are up to us, and that we sometimes are able to choose what we will do?

This is the question we'll be asking ourselves for the next two weeks. Our discussion will involve us considering the three strongest arguments **against** the view that we have free will.

But before doing that it is worth asking why there is any reason to accept the common view that we do have free will. Are there any arguments in favor of the reality of free will?

There are. The first argument starts with an apparent fact about moral responsibility: it seems (at least to a first approximation) that we are only responsible for actions which we freely perform. If you find out that someone's action was not done of their own free will, then it would be odd to blame them for their action.

But it also seems that people are at least sometimes genuinely responsible for their actions.

This suggests the following simple argument:

1. If someone's action is not free, then they are not responsible for that action.
 2. We are all responsible for at least some of our actions.
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C. At least some of our actions are free.

The argument from moral responsibility

How should someone who does not believe in free will respond?

A second argument is similar, and starts from an apparent fact about relationships:

genuinely loving relationships of a certain sort must be freely entered into.

This is not true of all loving relationships; for example, the love of a child for a parent is an obvious counterexample. But certain kinds of loving relationships, like those between spouses or friends, seem to require an element of freedom.

But if this is true then we can construct an argument in the obvious way:

1. Certain kinds of loving relationships must be freely entered into.
 2. These kinds of loving relationships exist.
-

C. People in such relationships exercise free will.

The argument from loving relationships

A third argument begins with the premise that it really, really, seems as though we have
free will.

This, by itself, might not seem to be a very impressive fact. But consider for a moment your beliefs about the color of the carpet. Do you have any reason for believing that the carpet is a certain color other than that it really seems to you to be that color?

Of course, you wouldn't form your belief about the carpet if you knew that you were wearing tinted glasses or otherwise subject to an illusion of some kind. But your current situation is not like that; you have no particular reason to doubt that the world is as it seems.

This might suggest the following general rule:

If the world seems to you to be some way, and you have no reason to doubt that the world is that way, then you should believe that the world is that way.

But then we can argue as follows:

What we are going to see over the next three classes is that premise (3) of this argument can be called into question.

THE ARGUMENT FROM SEEMING

1. It seems to me that I have free will.
2. If the world seems to you to be some way, and you have no reason to doubt that the world is that way, then you should believe that the world is that way.
3. I have no reason to doubt that I have free will.

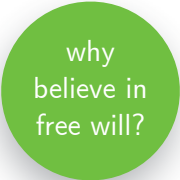
C. I should believe that I have free will.



two
arguments
against free
will



is fate
real?



why
believe in
free will?



three
ways out

Our first topic today is the oldest challenge to the existence of free will: the challenge to freedom that comes from fate.

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responsing assumes something about what we have free will.

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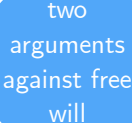
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We'll shortly consider some ways of

responding to Edwards' argument. But

first let's think about how Edwards'

for fatalsn.

argument might be related to an argument

God— and hence rejected premise (2) of

actions. Could they give an argument

Suppose that someone did not believe in

similar to Edwards' argument?

Edwards' argument — but did believe that

there were truths about all our future

replace reference to God's foreknowledge

with reference to the being of truth about

God only shows up in premises (2) and

(5) Let's look at what happens if we

our future actions.



God knows that in the future I will

that if it is true that I will perform

2* In the past, there were truths about

0 We have achieved what we

5* We have noticed that the fact

all of our activities.

3 We have not the fact that

some action, then I will prefer that

1. We have no direct facts.

4. If we have no choice about p , and no

will perform various actions.

acaioid.

perform a certain action (1,2)

then we have the choice about q.

(3, 4, 5)

choice about the fact that if p , then q ,



The fatalist argument

a Predictor. By the above line of thought, this person would lack free will. But

that Predict did not **take away** their free will; it just shows them that they

So now consider a possible scenario in which someone exactly like you would get

never had any. So they lacked free will before getting a Predict.

either.

But this person was stipulated to be exactly like you. So you don't have free will,

things as fate, then there is no free will.

and the example of the Predictor — which seem to show that if there is such a

So far we've looked at two imaginary thought experiments—the story of Osmo,

Our question is: do either fatigue or foreknowledge pose a

serious challenge to the reality of free will?